Sign Contract For New Health Center

$1,058,000 Facility Up In A Year

A $1,539,000 contract for construction of a new building to house the Wayne Miner Health Center was signed Tuesday, November 25, with the contract to build going to the Bob Eldridge Construction company.

Signing the contract were Dr. Samuel U. Rodgers for the Health Center and Karl Eldridge, vice-president of the construction firm. The signing ceremony took place at the present Health Center on the second floor of a Wayne Miner housing project building at 911 Michigan. The signing followed two hours of discussion over the availability of minority group construction workers for jobs on the project.

Under government regulations, the construction company is required to sign an Affirmative Action agreement pledging himself not only to non-discriminatory placement and promotion but to engage in non-discriminatory recruiting for workers.

The contractor also is required to give some training and employment to hard-core unemployed.

Total Cost $2,058,000

The new building, which will cost a total of $2,058,000 including land, construction, equipment and architect's fees, will be erected on the northeast corner of Ninth and Euclid, directly across the street from the Wayne Miner Housing project where the health center is now temporarily located.

The contract calls for the building to be erected in 365 calendar days. The work is scheduled to begin within 20 days after the signing of the contract.

Eldridge did not submit the low bid, it was learned. The low bid was made by the Empire Construction company but it required two years for construction. The bid was awarded to Eldridge because of his agreement to complete the building in one year, Dr. Rodgers said. Four bids were submitted.

A lengthy discussion was held with officials of the Office of Economic Opportunity, the Human Resources Corporation, the F.H.A., the Health Center and the construction firm participating. The long-standing policy of many labor unions to refuse employment to members of mi-

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from Washington, insisted, however, tht the contractor could do much to see that the unions open up to minority groups.

"The contractor has rapport with the unions," Dillon said, "while the little man doesn't. Sometimes the unions won't even talk to the little man looking for a job."

Dillon suggested that the contractor agree to escort potential workers to the unions and help them get consideration. This "escort clause" will be incorporated in the affirmative action agreement.

On this matter of the employment of black workers in the construction industry, Chester Stovall, executive director of the H.R.C., said that the old excuse that blacks cannot pass examinations should be discarded.

"I believe there are blacks who can pass any examination. We need to pay as much attention to people as we do to fiscal control and the tension of steel." He said that he was impressed by the number of graduates in a recent New Careers class. He said that if the poor want to earn money, the construction industry is the place to go with plumbers making over $9 an hour. "When they say that blacks can't pass the examinations, they just haven't looked and searched hard enough to find people who can pass it."

Negroes have been turned down by the unions so long that they are reluctant to keep knocking on the door, Stovall said.

'Can Be Found'

Black people capable of performing construction jobs can be found, Stovall said.

"They held up construction of the arch in St. Louis for months until they found black workers," Stovall said. "You can find them if you put your mind to it."

Dr. Rodgers said that he appreciated the necessity of making sure that black workers would be employed in the construction of the health center but he is anxious to get construction started. "The health center has been a center of controversy ever since it opened," Dr. Rodgers said. "We are burdened with all the woes of the world." He commented that a $12,000,000 Osteopathic hospital is under construction right across the street from the health center "and nobody is picketing there over employment policies." Dr. Rodgers said that if he thought holding up construction of the health center would "solve the union problem, I'd say go on. "But I don't want this thing stopped at the expense of people who need health care."

The architect on the project is Edmund Holmes Waddington. The Walker Electric company was awarded the sub-contract for electrical work.

Others attending the meeting Tuesday were: LaVannes Squires of Swope Parkway National bank; Charles Wymes of the Mid-Central Mortgage company, through which the project will be financed; Dr. Edwin Wicks, Kansas City health director; Norman Tucker, O.E.O.; Dr. V. L. Dixon, vice chairman of the Health Center board of directors; Frank Priest, F.H.A. contractor compliance officer; Richard Erickson, attorney.

Health Center staff members present beside Dr. Rodgers were Harry Gumby, administrative assistant; Bill Smith, business manager; Oscar Jamerson, assistant business manager; James Nunnelly, director of personnel; Rosalee Watkins, director of training; Dr. Robert Ellis, dental director; Gerald Mazzola, technical assistant, and Sheri Calloway, occupational analyst.

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nority groups was discussed extensively.

Problem With Unions

Karl Eldridge, representing the contractor, said that having too few black and other minority workers employed was not so much a problem with the cntractor as with the unions. "The contractor wants as much help as he can get, "El[illegible]idge said.

Charles Dillon, O.E.O. director of engineers who came here

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